



Ludwig II's pocket watch

△ The front of the watch casing, showing the king's monogram

his 19th-century pocket watch bearing a crown and monogram on the front, and a horse's

head on the reverse, was most likely made for King Ludwig II of Bavaria, an eccentric and controversial figure who died in strange circumstances.

The pocket watch was made in around 1880 and consists of gold, enamel, diamond, and ruby, with a matching chain and fob seal.

An applied gold-mounted, diamond-set entwined monogram of Ludwig II, surmounted by his crown, adorns the front of the case. On the reverse of the watch, is a silver-mounted, pavé-set diamond horse's head, with ruby-set eye: this elaborate



Ludwig II of Bavaria, who ruled the country from 1864 until his deposition in 1886

decoration acknowledges Ludwig's passion for horses. The gold-link chain of textured knots and four turquoise-and diamond-set, barrel-shaped links, representing the Bavarian coat-of-arms, terminates in a fob seal of a gold horse leaping from a turquoise cabochon.

Ludwig II was just 18 years old when he took the throne. Young and good-looking, he was popular in Bavaria, but was little concerned with affairs of state, instead commissioning fanciful

constructions such as the fairy-tale Neuschwanstein Castle. His ministers deposed him by having him declared mentally unsound in 1886, and Ludwig was removed to Castle Berg on Lake Starnberg on 12 June. The next day, his body was found in shallow water with that of his minder, Dr von Gudden. His watch had stopped at 6:54pm. Although suicide by drowning was reported as the cause of death, no water was found in his lungs, and his death remains unexplained. This watch – not the one present at his death – was auctioned in 2007.



The music room at Neuschwanstein Castle, the lavish 19th-century castle, still open to visitors today, that was one of Ludwig II's pet projects and where he intended to hide from the public eye

Key dates

1806–2007

